Underground food Academy

Cooking Class - Knife Skills

January 18, 2009

Instructor - Eric White

Welcome to the Underground Food Academy Knife Skills course. By the end of this course you should have additional knowledge in knife safety, knife usage and lots of skills to go home and practice.

Purpose:

- Learn about knife safety in a kitchen
- Learn how to hold a knife
- Learn how to use a knife and cutting board to best effect
- Learn how to chop a variety of vegetables
- Learn about different size dices
- HAVE FUN!

Addendum:

- Knife sharpening in the Bay Area
- What knives you should own
- A good selection of Chef Knives and some reviews

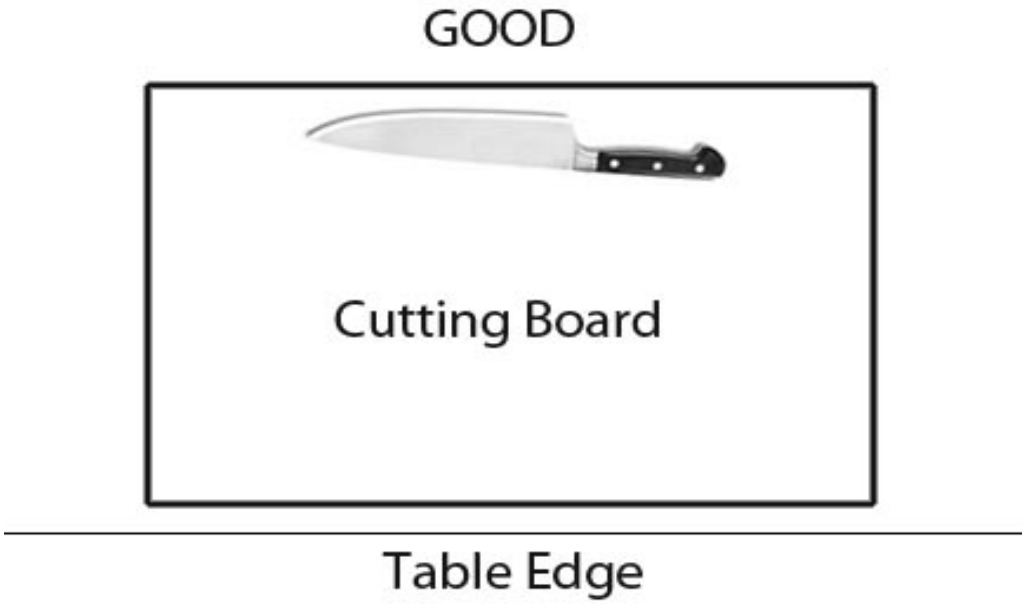
Introduction

The use of knives to cut vegetables and other food for cooking goes back as far as recorded history and their designs and styles are as numerous. Learning how to cut, chop, dice and stay safe is one of the best skills a home chef can practice or master.

When you use knives in a kitchen, remember, they will always get duller as you go on. Every time the knife comes in contact with a surface it will dull it or reduce its effectiveness. Using a “steel” will help to keep a knife blade “true” as you use it.

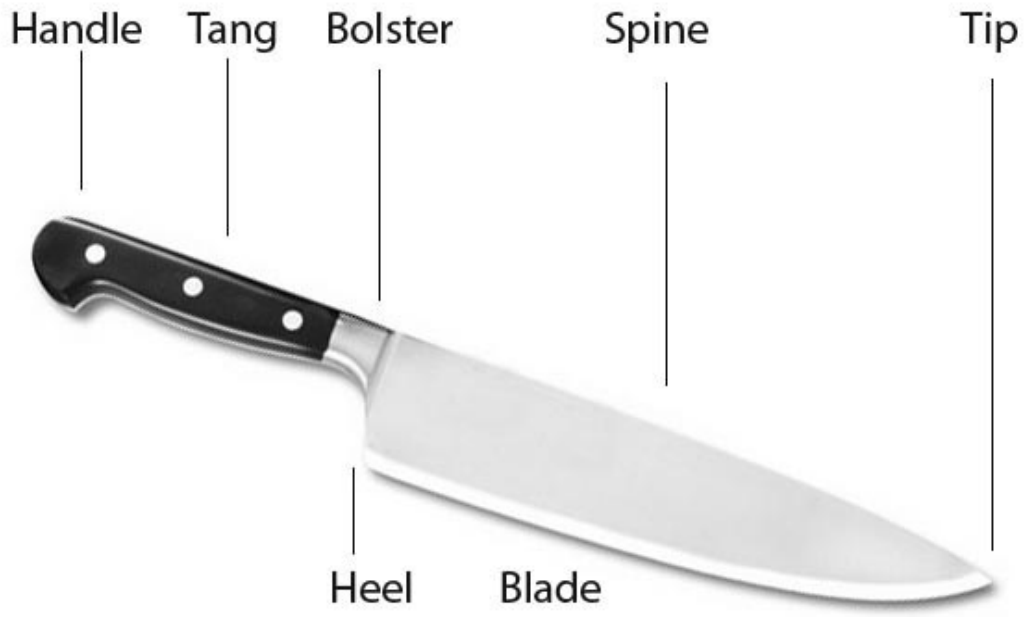
Knife Safety

- When walking through a kitchen it is best to keep a knife down at your side with the blade facing backward. If you tumble the knife goes out to the side and is less likely to cause harm. If passing behind someone say “knife” to let them know you are behind them and if you hear someone say “knife” please do not move and look before doing anything.
- Your toes and fingers are more expensive than your knife. If a knife falls, jump back and let it hit the floor. DO NOT try to catch it with your hand, your feet or anything else.
- When not using a knife, keep it parallel to the edge of the table, at the top of the cutting board.



Setting up your station

- Make sure your station is at the right height for you. Standard heights for a prep table are 33 inches, but a higher or lower table may be a better fit.
- Standing will give you more control when you are chopping, but if you like to sit at a table while cutting vegetables, give standing a try to see which works better for you.
- Place a wet cloth flat under your cutting board to prevent the board from moving.
- Give yourself enough room so you are not crowded.
- Have a variety of containers right by the board to put your chopped veggies or other items in.
- Make sure you have the right tools for the job; if you are cutting big items a Chef’s knife is great, but for garlic or other small items a paring knife may be a better choice and if you are slicing, you may want to get a slicing knife.
- “mis en place”, the French term meaning “make in place” is a good practice of getting into before cooking. You get everything together and put it where you can get to it easily before starting. It will make your life so much easier and less stressful if you know exactly where that special ingredient is before cooking or in the middle of prepping your food.



The Chef's Knife!

Most people learn to hold a knife by the handle only or to place their forefinger along the spine to give them more downward pressure.

A better technique is to hold it between the thumb and forefinger just forward of the bolster with the rest of your fingers around the handle.

One of the things to keep in mind when purchasing or using a chef's knife is that if it is not easy for you to hold, you should try another knife. In practice those with smaller hands find Global knives to be very comfortable and those with larger hands find a more traditional chef's knife to be a better fit, but it is good for you to try a variety before deciding to purchase one.

Chef's knives come in a variety of lengths from 6 to 12 inches. **8 inches** is the standard and will work for most tasks though you may find one that is longer or shorter to be better for you.

Using a Chef's Knife

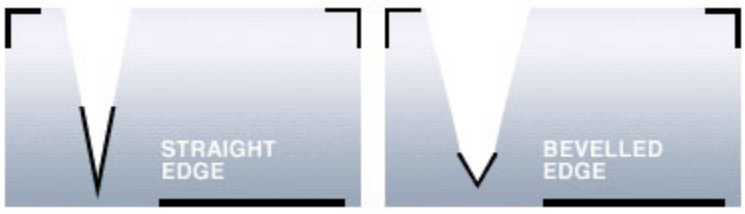
When you use a Chef's knife against a cutting board it is best to keep the tip in place and using a movement like shaking a hand you slide it forward and down keeping the blade in contact with the board and then back again. This motion means the knife is always in contact with the board and gives you greater control.

Another thing to notice is that when you cut (you can see this in the image below), the part of the knife that actually does most of the cutting is the 50% from the tip back.



Keeping a knife sharp:

It is important to "steel" a Chef's knife or any knife every 20 minutes or so when you are in the kitchen. As you use the knife the edge will fold over. When you run a knife along a "steel" it brings the knife back to a true edge. Additionally, depending on how often you use the knife, you should get it professionally sharpened every 3-6 months (there is a link to a list on yelp in the addendum). A dull knife is your worst enemy and will potentially cause you to work harder, have inconsistent results and to be more dangerous because dull knives can jump around and cut you which is NO FUN.



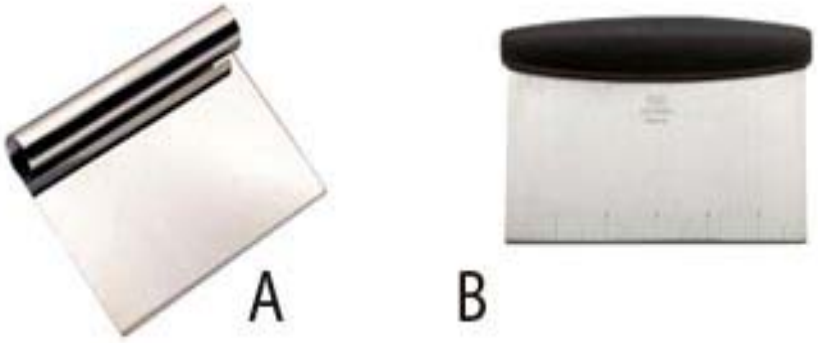
From http://www.justknives101.com/Global_Knife_Knives.aspx

Using a Knife as a scraper

When you scrape what you just cut from your board, never use the knife edge, use the spine. The little extra step will mean less professional sharpening, a better tool and more effectiveness at the cutting board.



An even better way to get the stuff you have chopped, diced, etc off the board is to get a Bash n Chop (A) or a pastry scraper (B). They are cheap and have many uses.

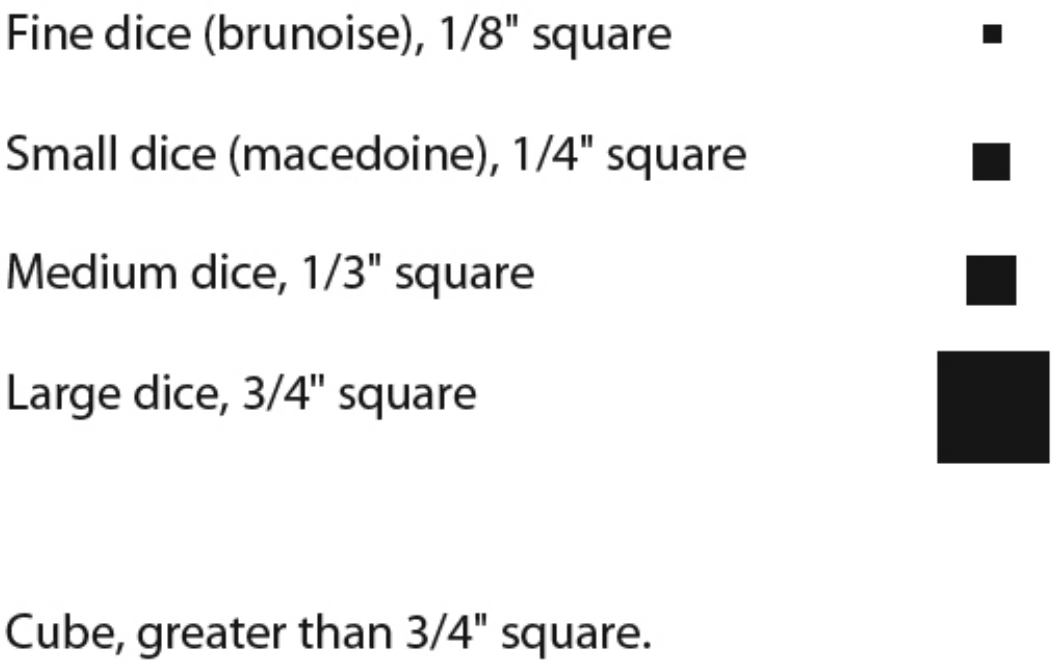


What size is best?

In general, small dices will disappear into whatever dishes you cook while larger dices will still be present at the end. This goes all the way up to throwing a full celery stalk into a stock so you can pull it out later.

Also, whatever you cook together will almost always need to be the same size to ensure it all cooks at the same rate. If you have small pieces of onion and rounds of carrots, the carrots will never be ready at the same time that the onion is cooked. (An exception to this is that many times you put garlic in at a later point in a dish and you dice it finer than the vegetables you start with)

Here are some classic definitions for dicing sizes;



General and specific tips

- Always try to flatten one side of what you are dicing before getting into it.
    - Cut an onion in half
    - Cut off part of a potato or carrot to give you a flat size
    - Cut a piece of celery while flat
    - Cut the bottom off a piece of fruit to give you a flat surface
    - Remove the stem from mushrooms before dicing or slicing

Exercises for this class:

- Chop a piece of celery to a fine dice
- Chop half an onion to a fine dice
- Chop a carrot to a fine dice
- Chop a carrot to a small dice
- Chop half an onion to a small dice
- Chop 5 mushrooms to a small dice
- Slice 5 mushrooms to ¼" thick slices
- Chop a potato to a medium dice
- Chop a potato to a large dice
- Slice a potato into ½" thick slices
- Slice the rind off a orange
- Slice the rind off a lemon
- Slice the rind off a grapefruit
- Section a Grapefruit
- Dice half a Green Pepper to a small dice
- Trim skin from green pepper
- Dice Half a green pepper to confetti (fine dice)

About The Instructor

Eric White grew up in a foodie family with a mother and father who cooked most meals from scratch. As a child he and his siblings helped in the kitchen to prep and cook the family meals marrying flavors from around the world into daily family meals. His family traveled extensively and Eric was exposed to many cultures, cooking styles and food types; many of which have become staples in his home and classes. In 1995, Eric started taking formal cooking classes in the Bay Area at a variety of schools to formalize his knowledge and then in 2001 he started assisting local and world renowned chefs and cookbook authors at Ramekins Cooking School in Sonoma. Since that time he moved from assistant to staff chef and has helped teach over 200 cooking classes in a variety of subjects, techniques, styles and cuisines at Ramekins Cooking School. Currently he runs a variety of underground food events, is one of the chefs for the staff at Burning Man, competes in the largest international BBQ cook-off in Houston, teaches private cooking classes and works with several caterers in the Bay Area.

Addendum

Knife Sharpening in the Bay Area

http://www.yelp.com/search?find_desc=knife+sharpening&find_loc=San+Francisco%2C+CA

Knives to own

http://www.taunton.com/finecooking/articles/three-must-have-knives.aspx

How to choose a knife

http://www.taunton.com/finecooking/articles/how-to-choose-chefs-knife.aspx

Consumer Reports on knives

For top performance:
Wüsthof Trident Classic #8418, $300
Henckels Twin Professional "S," $260

The Wüsthof and Henckels share the top rating; both give you superb performance. The Wüsthof comes with eight forged-steel knives; the Henckels has seven.

For value:
Chicago Cutlery Metropolitan, $60, CR Best Buy
Oxo Good Grips Professional, $100 CR Best Buy

Chicago Cutlery, a stamped-steel set, adds a parer, shears, steel, and block to the four basic knives. The stamped-steel Oxo set contains 14 knives.

Also, an inexpensive set, decent quality and a bargain though they do need a bit more work to stay sharp

3 Piece Proline Chef Knife Set

- http://www.knife-depot.com/knife-88029.html?src=froogle&src1=kd&src2=gbase&utm_source=Froogle&utm_medium=Product%2BSearch%2BEngine
- http://www.knife-depot.com/custom/search.php?search=proline&submit.x=0&submit.y=0&submit=submit